

# Optatus 367

## Lib. I, cap. 26 — the imperial commissioners' ruling (CSEL 26, pp. 28–29)

26. At the same time this same Donatus petitioned that he might be permitted to return \*\* [and] go to Carthage. Then, through Filuminus his supporter, it was suggested to the emperor that, for the good of peace, Caecilian should be detained at Brixia; and it was done. Then two bishops were sent to Africa, Eunomius and Olympius, to ordain one [bishop] once the two [rivals] had been removed. They came and were at Carthage forty days, in order to pronounce where the catholic [Church] was. The seditious party of Donatus did not allow this to be done; out of partisan zeal daily uproars were raised. The final sentence of these same bishops, Eunomius and Olympius, is read to this effect: that they declared the catholic [Church] to be that which was spread throughout the whole world, and that the sentence of the nineteen bishops, given long before, could not be dissolved. So they entered into communion with Caecilian's clergy and returned. Of these matters we have a volume of records, which anyone who wishes may read in the concluding sections. While these things were happening, Donatus of his own accord returned first to Carthage. On hearing this, Caecilian hastened to his own people. In this way the parties were once more revived. Nevertheless it stands established both that Donatus was struck down by so many sentences and that Caecilian was pronounced innocent by as many sentences.

## Lib. II, cap. 2 — the endowments; the one chair conferred first on Peter (CSEL 26, pp. 35–36)

2. Therefore, since we have proved that Church to be catholic which is spread throughout the whole world, its ornaments must now be recounted, and it must be seen where its five endowments are — which you said were six — among which the chair (*cathedra*) is first; and unless a bishop has sat upon it, the second endowment, which is the angel, cannot be joined to it. It must be seen who first sat in the chair, and where. If you do not know, learn; if you do know, blush: ignorance cannot be imputed to you, so it remains that you must know [it]. For one who knows to err, [it] is a sin; whereas the ignorant are sometimes wont to be pardoned. Therefore you cannot deny that you know that in the city of Rome the episcopal chair was first conferred on Peter, in which sat Peter, the head of all the apostles — whence too he was called Cephas — the one chair in which unity was to be preserved by all, lest the other apostles should each claim separate chairs for themselves; so that he would now be a schismatic and a sinner who should set up another chair against the single chair.

## **Lib. II, cap. 3 — the succession to Siricius; the whole world in one communion by the *formatae* (CSEL 26, pp. 36–37)**

3. Therefore in the single chair, which is the first of the endowments, Peter sat first, to whom Linus succeeded; to Linus succeeded Clement, [[p. 37]] to Clement Anacletus, to Anacletus Euaristus, to Euaristus [Alexander; to Alexander] Sixtus, to Sixtus Telesphorus, to Telesphorus Iginus, to Iginus Anicetus, to Anicetus Pius, to Pius Soter, to Soter [Eleutherius; to Eleutherius] Uictor, to Uictor Zephyrinus, to Zephyrinus Calixtus, to Calixtus Urbanus, to Urbanus Pontianus, to Pontianus Anterus, to Anterus Fabianus, to Fabianus Cornelius, to Cornelius Lucius, to Lucius Stephanus, to Stephanus Sixtus, to Sixtus Dionysius, to Dionysius Felix, to Felix [Eutychianus; to Eutychianus Gaius; to Gaius] Marcellinus, to Marcellinus [Marcellus; to Marcellus] Eusebius, to Eusebius Miltiades, to Miltiades Silvester, to Silvester Marcus, to Marcus Iulius, to Iulius Liberius, to Liberius Damasus, to Damasus Siricius — who today is our associate: with whom the whole world concords with us in one fellowship of communion, through the exchange of letters of communion (*formatae*). Render the origin of your own chair, you who wish to claim the holy Church for yourselves.

## **Lib. III, cap. 9 — the whole world rejoices, except a part of Africa (CSEL 26, pp. 92–94)**

9. The whole world rejoices in catholic unity except the part of [[p. 93]] Africa, in which a fire has been kindled from a spark. You complain that certain things — I know not what — were committed by the workers of unity. Of this Italy does not complain, nor Gaul, nor Spain, nor Pannonia, nor Galatia, nor Greece, nor Asia with all its many provinces. Because there was nothing there to be mended, no mender was sent thither; because nothing there had been torn, no patcher — so to speak — was sent thither. And here in Africa, while the people had long remained in unity, the garment had been whole, [but] was torn asunder by the jealous hand of the enemy. The pieces of cloth were hanging, as it were, from one origin of the garment, and the branches, coming from one root, were divided from one another. Why does part set itself before part? Why does one piece of cloth exalt itself over another piece, when it will not be able to prove itself the better? For what [could it say]? If the despised piece should say: ‘Why do you exalt yourself so? Did we not grow up equal, were we not together in the hands of those who made us, were we not cleansed alike at the fuller’s? The enemy wished to cut us off from one another; the adversary wished to deface our beauty.’ In part of the garment we are still one, but we hang in different places. For what has been torn has been divided in part, not in whole, since it is rightly established that our ecclesiastical manner of life and yours is one, and if the minds of men are at strife, the sacraments are not at strife. In short, we too can say: ‘We believe equally and are sealed with one seal, [[p. 94]] nor are we baptized otherwise than you; we read the divine testament alike, we pray to one God alike, the Lord’s Prayer is one and the same with us and with you. But, the garment having been torn, as we said above, with the pieces hanging on this side and that, a mending had become necessary.’ And yet, when the craftsman or worker of this task wishes to restore the garment to its former appearance, he pricks the neighboring threads. The patcher displeases you, who, while he heals the tear, wounds it; [rather] let him displease you who brought it about that the patcher could do harm. And the things

which you say were committed against you by the workers of unity either pertain to your forefathers, for whose sake they were done, or descend from the will of God; but from these we are strangers.

## **Lib. VII, cap. 5 — the unanswerable marks: one communion with the whole world (CSEL 26, pp. 176–178)**

5. For what sort of thing is this, that at your own whim you have chosen to impose on us the person of Moses, against whom, as the apostle Paul relates, Jannes and Jambres set themselves? If it is so, what truth can be found among you, to which the catholic [Church] seems to be opposed; or what falsehood among us will you be able to prove? To be in one communion with the whole world — will you be able to prove that a falsehood? To hold and defend the true and only creed — will you be able to prove that a falsehood? The chair of Peter and the keys of the kingdom of heaven granted by Christ, [[p. 177]] where our fellowship is — will you be able to prove that a falsehood? In the very passage which you have cited, among the persons themselves, consider the order of things, and mark who came first. Assuredly Jannes and Jambres are in the second place, who wished to war against Moses and the truth by false arts. And Moses had gone before, whose powers they tried in vain to assail. As Moses is prior, so too the catholic [Church] is prior; as Jannes and Jambres withstood in opposition, so too you, as rebels, war against the true catholic [Church]. What then is the reason that you have wished to exchange the names both for us and for you, unless it be to make yourself equal to your associates? For there are some among you who, forgetful or ignorant of past times, direct against us what pertains to those who, having long ago fallen from the catholic [Church], ordained Maiorinus — those, namely, the authors of schism and of the handing-over [of the scriptures]. While they still held onto peace, before they exterminated the God-pleasing unity, they were the light of the world and were deservedly called the salt of the earth. While they taught peace, they were still called peacemakers; before they were puffed up, they were blessed for poverty of spirit, they were part of the seasoning; they were blessed while meek, they were part of the seasoning; they were blessed while just, they were part of the seasoning; blessed, while peacemakers, they had been the whole seasoning. After they gave the riches of error to their spirit and their lungs, and, making schism, were found unmerciful and less compassionate, when impiously [[p. 178]] they divided the members of the Church and, following injustice, held the kingdom of God in disdain, and by dividing the Church were unwilling to be peacemakers, they themselves became salt made tasteless, by which nothing could be seasoned that might have pleased God with its savor. And although this evil pertains to your leaders, by some of your associates it is argued otherwise, so that they say those were foolish who acknowledged the truth even if late, and, withdrawing from schism, having recognized the catholic mother, followed peace. These some of you think erred; these they suppose to have withdrawn from wisdom as though made tasteless. Whence it appears that you all err in the same way in transferring the names, since both you compared Jannes and Jambres to the peacemaking catholics, and [compared] us schismatics to Moses — which is foreign to the truth. And some of your associates have wished to judge the wise as foolish, so as to say that the peacemakers were made fools, and they were unwilling to understand that their own forefathers were made tasteless by dissension.

## Appendix IV — the Council of Arles to Pope Silvester, A.D. 314 (CSEL 26, pp. 206–208)

[IV.] To the most beloved pope Silvester: Marinus, Acratius, Natalis, Theodorus, Proterius, Uocius, Uerus, Probatius, Caecilianus, Faustinus, Surgentius, Gregorius, Reticius, Ambitausus, Termatius, Merocles, Pardus, Adelfius, Hibernius, Fortunatus, Aristasius, Lampadius, Uitalis [and] Maternus, Liberius, Gregorius, Crescens, Auitianus, Dafnus, Orantalis, Quintasius, Uictor, Epictetus — eternal [[p. 207]] salvation in the Lord! Cleaving by the common bond of charity and by the tie of the unity of the catholic mother Church, having been brought by the will of the most pious emperor to the city of Arles, from there we greet you, most glorious pope, with due reverence. Here we have endured a grave and pernicious injury to our law and tradition, and men of unbridled mind, whom both the present authority of our God and tradition and the rule of truth so reject that in them there subsisted no manner of speaking, nor any mode of accusing, nor any proof [that] would fit: therefore, with God and mother Church — who knows and approves her own — as judge, they were either condemned or repulsed. And would that, most beloved brother, you had thought it worth so much to be present at this great spectacle! Assuredly we believe that a severer sentence would have been pronounced against them, and, with you judging together with us, our assembly would have exulted with greater joy. But since you were by no means able to withdraw from those regions, in which the apostles also daily sit and their blood without intermission testifies to the glory of God, nevertheless these were not the only matters that seemed to us to require treatment, dearest brother, to which we had been invited, but we resolved that we ourselves must also take counsel; and because the provinces from which we have come are diverse, so also various things arise which we judge ought to be observed. It pleased [us] therefore, in the presence of the Holy Spirit and his angels, that out of those matters which severally moved each of us, we should render judgment concerning the present tranquillity; it pleased [us] also that it be first written to you — who hold the greater dioceses — [and] that through you above all it be made known to all. But what it is that we have decided, we have appended in the writing of our lowliness. And this had to be treated in the first place, concerning our life and welfare: that, [inasmuch as] he who is one died for many and rose again, the season itself should by all be observed with a mind so religious that no divisions or dissensions may arise in so great a service of devotion. We judge, therefore, that the Lord's Pascha be observed on one day throughout the whole world. Concerning these too, who in whatever places have been ordained ministers, [we judge] that they remain in those same places. For the matter concerns those who throw down their arms in [time of] peace: it pleased [us] that they be kept from communion. Concerning the circus charioteers who are of the faithful, [[p. 208]] it pleased [us] that, so long as they drive, they be separated from communion. Concerning stage-players (*theictrici*), it pleased [us] that they too, so long as they perform, be separated from communion. The matter concerns those who are set in sickness and wish to believe: it pleased [us] that the hand be laid upon them. But concerning governors who are of the faithful and advance to the governorship, it pleased [us] thus: that, when they have been promoted, they should indeed receive ecclesiastical letters of communion, yet on this condition, that in whatever places they administer, care be taken of them by the bishops of that same place, and if they begin to act against discipline, then at last they be excluded from communion. And concerning those, indeed, who wish to engage in public affairs, likewise. But concerning Africa, that they use their own peculiar law, so as to rebaptize, it pleased [us] that, if any heretic come to the Church, they question him [on] the creed; and if they perceive that he was baptized in the Father and the Son and the

Holy Spirit, let the hand only be laid on him; but if, being questioned, he does not answer this creed of the Trinity, let him deservedly be baptized, and so forth. Then, growing weary, [the president] ordered all to return to their own sees. Amen.